

Phases of the Moon

The Moon's shape seems to change night by night — these are its phases, cycling about once a month.

The Moon's changing shapes

The **phases of the Moon** are the changing shapes of its bright portion as seen from Earth. The Moon does **not make its own light** — it shines by **reflecting sunlight**.

Period	What happens	Indian name
Waxing	Bright part grows: new → full (~2 weeks)	Shukla Paksha
Waning	Bright part shrinks: full → new (~2 weeks)	Krishna Paksha

Key days and shapes

- **Full Moon (Purnima)** — whole bright circle visible.
- **New Moon (Amavasya)** — Moon not visible.
- **Gibbous** — more than half lit; **Crescent** — less than half lit.

The full cycle from one full Moon to the next takes about **a month (~29.5 days)**.

Note: the Moon itself doesn't change shape — only how much of its lit half we can see changes.

Where students lose marks

Trap 1 — Waxing = growing, waning = shrinking. Shukla Paksha (waxing) ends at full Moon; Krishna Paksha (waning) ends at new Moon.

Trap 2 — The Moon doesn't shine on its own. It reflects sunlight.

Trap 3 — Gibbous > half lit; crescent < half lit. Don't mix them up.

Model answers — write them like this

Example A. The Moon's bright part is growing each night. Which period is it?

Step 1: Growing bright part = waxing.

∴ It is the waxing period (Shukla Paksha), heading towards full Moon.

Example B. Why does the Moon appear to shine?

Step 1: The Moon has no light of its own.

Step 2: It reflects sunlight falling on it.

∴ We see the sunlight it reflects.

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